

Name: Incompleteness

Players: 2

Duration: This game can be finished within 15 minutes unless players prefer to take more time to think.

Age: 10+? 8+?

BGG/BGA complexity score estimation: 2/5? 1/5?

Description:

Two players take turns placing only corner jigsaw pieces to score points in this abstract strategy game. If both players try to win then the board will most likely not be completely filled, hence the name.

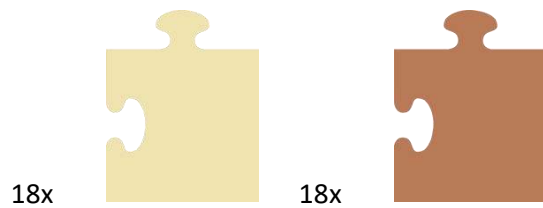
Game Components:

6x6 board (not checkered)

18 light corner jigsaw pieces (double sided)

18 dark corner jigsaw pieces (double sided)

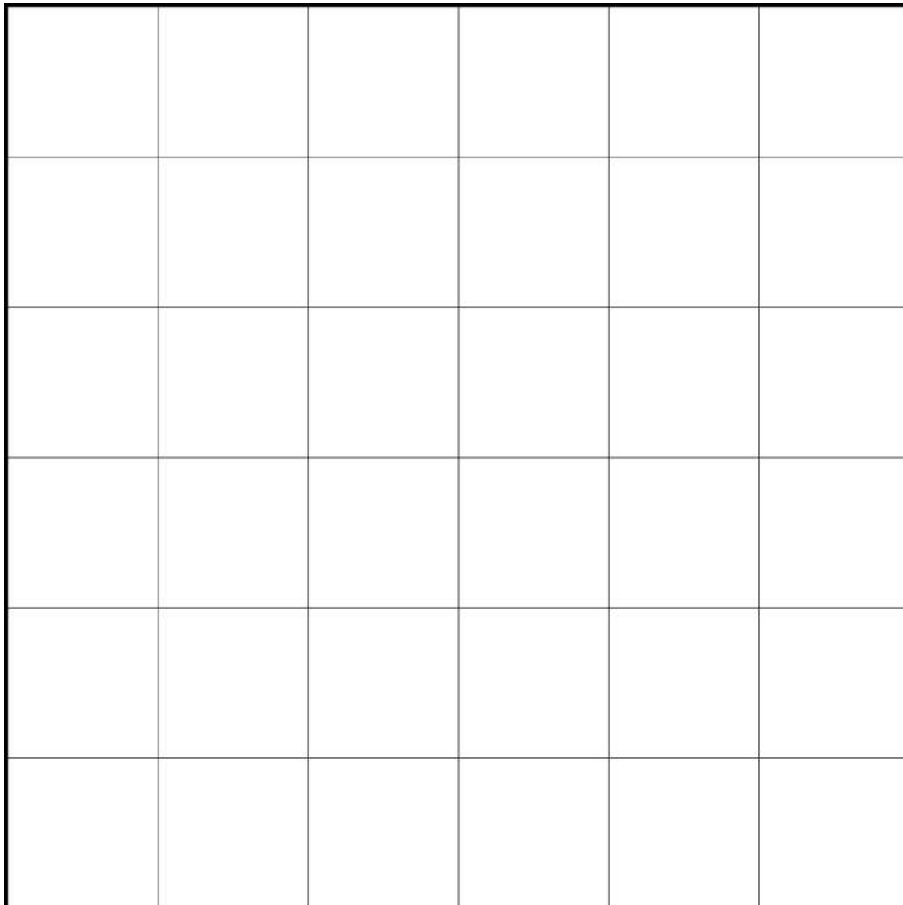
Each jigsaw piece has two straight edges, one tab and one blank.



18x

18x

1x



Gameplay/Rules:

The starting player can be determined randomly or by mutual agreement. Players must also agree whether to use the tie breaker.

The starting player proceeds by following the pie rule.

Players take turns. Each turn a player places one piece of their color on any unoccupied square of the total 36 squares of the board, according to the placement rules.

The game ends when a player cannot place a piece. The board may or may not be completed with all 36 pieces.

Pie Rule or Swap Rule:

The starting player places two light pieces and one dark piece according to the placement rules.

The other player then decides if they want to continue the game as the light player or the dark player.

The dark player then places a dark piece and the game continues as usual with the light player's turn.

Placement Rules:

Both sides (front and back) of the jigsaw piece can be used and the piece can be rotated.

Only the straight edges of a piece can be placed against the edge of the board.

Two pieces can only be placed orthogonally adjacent to each other if their straight edges touch or if the tab of one piece and the blank of the other piece interlock. In other words, tabs can never overlap with other pieces and blanks can never touch other blanks or straight edges.

Two orthogonally adjacent pieces can have different colors or the same color.

Two orthogonally adjacent pieces of the same color are considered connected and part of the same group. A single unconnected piece also counts as a group.

An unoccupied square can lose its ability to become occupied as a result of these placement rules.

Consider such square to be permanently blocked for both players.

Scoring:

Each player will have one or more groups of connected pieces of their own color.

For each group a player scores the triangular number of the amount of pieces in that group.

A player's total score is the sum of all those triangular numbers.

The player with the highest total score is the winner. If both total scores are equal then the game's result is considered a draw unless the use of the tie breaker was agreed upon before the start of the game.

Triangular Number Formula:

If the triangular number of n is T then

$$T = n(n+1)/2$$

(n multiplied by ($n+1$) divided by 2)

Table of Triangular Numbers:

n	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18
T	1	3	6	10	15	21	28	36	45	55	66	78	91	105	120	136	153	171

n	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32
T	190	210	231	253	276	300	325	351	378	406	435	465	496	528

Optional Tie Breaker:

In case of a tie, the dark player wins.

Multi-game Match:

Players can decide to play an odd number of games, add up their scores and compete for the higher total score.

If the total scores are equal and the tie breaker is used then the player who played as the dark player most often, wins the match.

Alternative Board Sizes:

This game can be played on X by X boards. Both players need $X^2/2$ (rounded down) pieces and the light player needs one more piece if X is an odd number. (A full board must be possible in theory.)

For example: a 7x7 board with 25 light pieces and 24 dark pieces. (Bigger board sizes will make it harder to calculate the scores. 8x8 may be too large for that reason.)

Connection Game Variant:

In this variant one rule is added to the game.

If a player connects two opposite sides of the board then the game ends immediately and that player is the winner.

In a multi-game match, the scores at that end of the game still count even if that player has a lower score.

This gives the players an incentive not to trigger the end of the game immediately and necessarily when they get the opportunity to do so.

Strategy Tips:

Good placements create potential for large groups and/or prevent the opponent from creating large groups. This usually means aiming to score higher triangular numbers and/or blocking important squares for the opponent.

Unoccupied squares at the edge of the board are more likely to become blocked.

During the pie rule phase, it is important that the beginning player gives both colors a roughly equal chance, as the other player gets to decide which color to play.

Inspiration:

This game idea was inspired by the scoring system from the game called "Ponte del Diavolo" (2007) and by tile placements and blocking from games like "Carcassonne" (2000). The aim was to create a visually intriguing and small game with few resources that wouldn't take too long to craft, learn and play.

The triangular number scoring seems to make a player's largest group the most important goal while letting the growth of smaller groups also be another relevant factor for the result of the game.

With the addition of the connection game variant rule, this game might at first glance fall into the same category as games like Hex (1942) and Twixt (1962). However, in this game, the goal to connect two opposite sides is often easily prevented by the other player. In practice, it is primarily a tactical threat to achieve the other goal of scoring points.

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Finished Game Example:



In this finished game example, the light player is the winner.